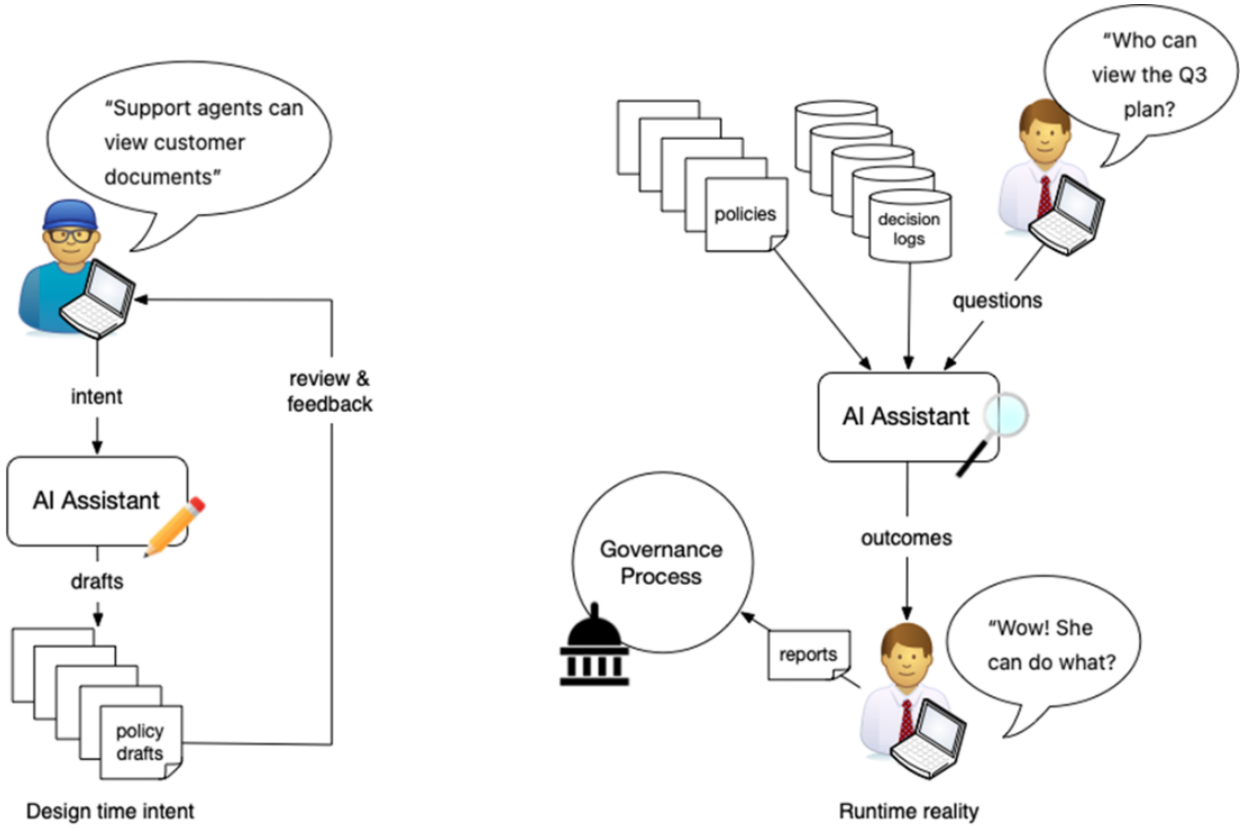


Figure 17.3 Design-time intent versus runtime reality. Authorization policies are created to express intent at design time, while their effects are revealed through observed decisions at runtime. Comparing these two perspectives—how policies were intended to work and how they actually behave in production—helps teams identify mismatches, unexpected outcomes, and areas that need governance review.

The remainder of this section examines how AI-assisted analysis reveals that reality and how these insights contribute to clearer, more accountable policy design.

17.3.1 Seeing what policies really do

At ACME, policy owners often had a clear mental model of what a policy was supposed to do. For example, a statement like "support agents can view customer documents" sounded straightforward and aligned with business expectations. However, once deployed, that intent was influenced by various factors: workspace membership, document ownership, delegated roles, time-based conditions, and device posture.